Cuban missile crisis: the White House was about to be visited by no less a figure than the Soviet foreign minister, Andrei Gromyko.

Gromyko was visiting the United Nations and made a stopover in the American capital. Khrushchev and his colleagues in the Presidium wanted Gromyko to feel Kennedy out and try to predict his possible reaction to the impending Soviet announcement, to be made after the congressional elections, of the placement of missiles in Cuba. John McCone had a different agenda for Kennedy. In the memorandum he had submitted to the president the previous day, he warned him that "the United States should not act without warning and thus be forced to live with a 'Pearl Harbor indictment' for the indefinite future." He wanted Kennedy to "notify Gromyko and Castro that we know all about this" and "give them 24 hours to commence dismantling and removal of MRBMs, coastal defense missiles, surface to air missiles, IL 28s and all other aircraft which have a dual defensive-offensive capability, including MIG 21s."[8]

Kennedy met with Gromyko in the presence of Rusk, and they did not follow McCone's advice. Kennedy was still in favor of an attack without warning, while Rusk believed that it was premature to mention anything to Gromyko before the internal deliberations were over and the president had made up his mind. One way or another, Kennedy and Rusk remained silent about the missiles. Gromyko, for his part, acted as if the missiles did not exist. His main topic was Berlin, where he threatened escalation after the November elections. On Cuba, he attacked the United States for old-fashioned imperialism. He admitted that the Soviets had supplied weapons and trained Cubans in their use. Gromyko referred to the weapons delivered by the Soviets as "defensive," thereby contradicting Kennedy's description of them earlier in the conversation as "offensive" weapons. By this logic, if the Soviet ballistic missiles were to be used to defend Cuba, then they were not "offensive" weapons, as Kennedy had referred to them in his statement of September 11. With this diplomatic legerdemain, Gromyko was seeking to assert that the Kennedy administration could have no legitimate objection to the Soviet weapons deployed on the island.

"President Kennedy listened astonished, but also with some admiration for the boldness of Gromyko's position," wrote Robert Kennedy in his account of the crisis. Kennedy was silent on the missiles but said that he